

Ukraine faces a critical human capital trilemma: insufficient returnees, acute skill gaps requiring foreign specialists, and ongoing brain drain risks. The URC 2026 in Gdańsk spotlighted diaspora reactivation and veteran reskilling as priority levers. Ukraine's top-4 global ranking for software developers signals untapped retention and recruitment potential.

Budanov's call for foreign specialists confirms domestic talent supply is critically insufficient — Ukraine must simultaneously recruit externally, retain tech talent, and accelerate diaspora return to avoid collapse of reconstruction workforce.

RETURN

ICMPD: Recovery Hinges on Returnees, Diaspora and Veterans

At URC 2026 in Gdańsk, ICMPD Director General Raab emphasized Ukraine's recovery depends on mobilizing displaced persons, returnees, youth, women, veterans, and older workers. Diaspora reactivation was framed as a structural necessity, not optional.

3R: Directly validates the Return pillar — multilateral institutions now treating diaspora reactivation as a core recovery mechanism, not supplementary.

FACEBOOK / ICMPD

Joint HR Statement: Labour Market Needs Returning Displaced

A joint statement by national and international human rights organizations at URC 2026 noted reconstruction costs near \$588B and flagged Ukraine's increasingly strained labour market. Return of displaced persons identified as essential to fill reconstruction workforce gaps.

3R: Quantifies the scale of workforce deficit linked to displacement, reinforcing urgency of return-focused policies.

CRIMEA HUMAN RIGHTS GROUP

RECRUIT

Budanov: Ukraine Has No Choice But to Recruit Foreign Specialists

Ukraine's intelligence chief Budanov stated foreign specialists are unavoidable for reconstruction. Only 11,000+ labor migrants currently work in Ukraine as of 2026, far below demand. Structural talent shortages across critical sectors require active international recruitment.

3R: Strongest recruit signal of the week — highest-level Ukrainian official confirming international hiring as state necessity for reconstruction.

KYIV POST

Ukraine Ranks #4 Globally for Software Developer Talent

Employsome's 2026 research ranks Ukraine #4 globally for software developer hiring quality. Employer of Record frameworks enable foreign companies to recruit Ukrainian tech talent compliantly, maintaining talent engagement even amid war.

3R: Highlights Ukraine as a recruit destination for tech roles; EOR models can also help channel diaspora tech workers back into Ukrainian economic circuits.

EMPLOY SOME

Veteran Reskilling: Rebuild Skills Lab at BSPU Launches July 2026

Bogdan Khmelnytsky State Pedagogical University launches 'Reintegrate & Rebuild' micro-credential programs for veteran reskilling in July 2026. Veterans are positioned as an internal talent pool to recruit into civilian reconstruction workforce.

3R: Critical recruit-from-within strategy — converting veterans into skilled civilian workforce reduces dependency on external foreign specialist recruitment.

BDPU NEWS

RETAIN

Rehabilitation Programme Ukraine: GIZ Partnership Signed at URC 2026

Ukraine's Ministry of Health and GIZ signed a Statement of Intent at URC 2026 to implement the Rehabilitation Programme Ukraine (RPU). Accessible rehabilitation infrastructure is a key retention factor for wounded veterans and displaced persons considering return.

3R: Rehabilitation capacity directly impacts retain and return — workers and veterans need health support to remain economically active in Ukraine.

INSTAGRAM / RPU UKRAINE

Military School Graduation: Retaining Youth Within Defense Ecosystem

A Guardian photo essay documents graduation at a western Ukrainian military school with ~400 cadets nationwide. Structured military education pipelines retain youth within Ukraine's institutional framework, preventing emigration-driven demographic loss.

3R: Indirect retain signal — military education investment keeps youth cohorts anchored in Ukraine during war, building long-term human capital.

THE GUARDIAN

URC 2026 Business Side Events: Procurement Reform to Retain Investors

CES and PEI experts presented Ukrainian wartime public procurement experiences at URC 2026 business side events. Transparent procurement reform is essential to retain private sector confidence and skilled professionals working on reconstruction contracts.

3R: Business environment quality is a key retain driver — professionals and investors stay where governance is transparent and contracts are reliable.

URC INTERNATIONAL

GLOBAL CONTEXT

Tanzania/SADC Regional Displacement Dashboard — May 2026

ReliefWeb's RBESA dashboard covers refugees, returnees, and IDPs across the SADC region including DRC-Tanzania dynamics. Offers comparative methodology for tracking displaced population flows relevant to Ukraine's own return monitoring infrastructure.

3R: Comparative global case — SADC return-tracking dashboards offer replicable models for Ukraine's diaspora and returnee monitoring systems.

RELIEFWEB

Venezuela IOM Crisis Response Plan 2026: Migration Driver Lessons

IOM's Venezuela 2026 plan targets irregular migration drivers and displacement risks. Venezuela's experience with large-scale economically-driven diaspora and failed return programs offers cautionary parallels for Ukraine's post-war human capital planning.

3R: Negative benchmark — Venezuela illustrates risks when economic push factors dominate over pull factors, a dynamic Ukraine must actively counter.

IOM CRISIS RESPONSE
